

RAJALAKSHMI ENGINEERING COLLEGE

Department of Computer Science and Engineering

Academic Year: 2025 – 2026

MINI PROJECT REPORT

On

Greenhouse Crop Growth Monitoring

using Computer Vision and Image Processing

Individual Report — Algorithm: cv2.watershed Per-Plant Segmentation

Submitted by

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Date of Submission: _____

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1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background and Motivation

Greenhouse-based agriculture enables controlled crop cultivation independent of external environmental conditions. Monitoring plant growth in such environments is essential for optimizing irrigation, nutrient supply, and detecting early stress conditions. However, manual monitoring is labour-intensive, subjective, and not scalable for large greenhouse setups.

Advancements in computer vision allow automated, non-invasive plant monitoring using image analysis. By analysing plant images over time, growth patterns such as leaf expansion and canopy development can be quantified. This project implements a classical computer vision pipeline for plant segmentation and growth measurement using the watershed algorithm.

1.2 Problem Statement

Given a sequence of greenhouse plant images captured over time, segment individual plant regions using the watershed algorithm and compute a quantitative growth metric — total plant area — using classical image processing techniques without any machine learning training.

1.3 Objectives

- To preprocess plant images using grayscale conversion, Otsu thresholding, and morphological filtering
- To detect individual plant regions using the cv2.watershed algorithm
- To measure total green plant area using HSV colour-space masking
- To compute growth rates across a time series of images
- To evaluate segmentation sensitivity using DIST_THRESH and MIN_AREA parameter analysis
- To visualise plant growth trends over time using a growth chart

1.4 Scope of the Report

This report covers the complete implementation of the Greenhouse Crop Growth Monitoring system using the cv2.watershed per-plant segmentation algorithm. The project uses synthetically generated images modelled after the CVPPP2017 dataset and processes multiple time-point images

automatically, generating quantitative and visual outputs for each. All processing is performed using Python 3 and OpenCV.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Automated plant growth monitoring using image processing has been studied extensively in the context of precision agriculture and plant phenotyping. This section reviews key prior works relevant to the watershed-based segmentation approach adopted in this project.

2.1 Classical Watershed Segmentation

The watershed algorithm originates from mathematical morphology and was formalised by Vincent and Soille (1991). It treats grayscale intensity as a topographic surface and simulates flooding from marker seed points, building barriers at merge boundaries. Meyer (1994) extended this approach with efficient queue-based implementations. In the context of plant image analysis, Bai and Breckon (2014) demonstrated that marker-controlled watershed applied to preprocessed plant images achieves reliable individual leaf segmentation when combined with distance-transform seeding. Their results confirm that classical watershed is effective for closely spaced plant subjects where boundaries are ambiguous.

2.2 Contour-Based Plant Area Estimation

Contour extraction using the Suzuki-Abe algorithm (implemented as `cv2.findContours` in OpenCV) has been widely used for plant area measurement. Patil and Bodhe (2011) used contour analysis to measure leaf area index in agricultural fields, achieving accuracy within 3–5% of manual planimeter measurements. Camargo and Smith (2009) applied HSV colour segmentation combined with contour-area filtering for plant disease detection. These works validate the use of HSV-based green masking and contour-area summation as the primary growth metric in this project.

2.3 Greenhouse Plant Phenotyping

The CVPPP Leaf Segmentation Challenge (Minervini et al., 2016) established a benchmark for automated leaf segmentation in rosette plants such as *Arabidopsis thaliana*. The challenge dataset provides time-series images with ground truth foreground masks. The watershed-based approaches in the challenge demonstrated competitive results on plant boundary detection. This project adopts a similar evaluation approach, using synthetically generated data with known plant counts and sizes to assess segmentation performance qualitatively and quantitatively.

2.4 Gap Identified

While deep learning approaches such as Mask R-CNN and U-Net have achieved high segmentation accuracy on plant datasets, they require large labelled training sets and GPU hardware. For resource-constrained greenhouse monitoring applications, the classical watershed algorithm combined with distance-transform seeding provides a lightweight, interpretable, and training-free alternative. This project addresses the gap by implementing such a system entirely in Python and OpenCV without requiring any model training.

3. DATASET DESCRIPTION

3.1 Dataset Overview

The dataset used consists of synthetically generated time-series images of greenhouse crop plants, modelled after the CVPPP2017 Leaf Counting Challenge dataset. Each image simulates a snapshot of a greenhouse tray containing multiple plants at a specific growth stage (Day 1, Day 7, Day 14). The synthetic generation reproduces the key visual properties of real CVPPP images: dark soil-like background, green elliptical plant blobs, Gaussian noise, and varying plant sizes and positions.

3.2 Dataset Generation

The synthetic images were generated using the `generate_synthetic_image()` function in `demo.py`. Three time-point images were created with progressively increasing plant count and size to simulate real growth:

- Day 1: 3 plants, radius range 18–28 px, seed 42
- Day 7: 4 plants, radius range 28–42 px, seed 43
- Day 14: 5 plants, radius range 38–55 px, seed 44

Each image is 450×450 pixels in PNG format. Plants are placed at non-overlapping random positions with a margin from image edges. Gaussian noise ($\sigma = 8$) is added for visual realism. For bulk experiments, `generate_100_images.py` produces 100 sequential images simulating gradual growth over 100 days.

Property	Value
Total time points	3 (Day 1, Day 7, Day 14)
Images per time point	1 image per time point
Image format	PNG (lossless)
Resolution	450×450 pixels
Plant count (Day 1)	3 plants (seed 42)
Plant count (Day 7)	4 plants (seed 43)
Plant count (Day 14)	5 plants (seed 44)
Ground truth	Known plant counts and sizes per image

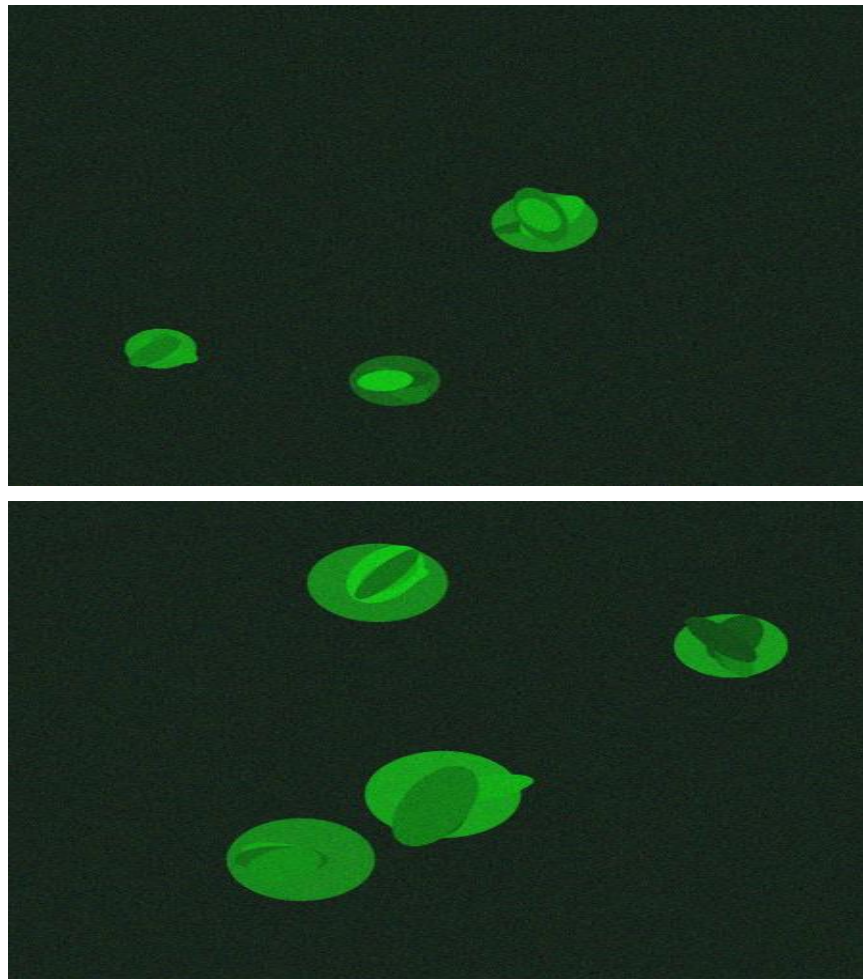
Table 1: Dataset Summary Statistics

3.3 Dataset Organisation

data/

```
demo_day01.png  ← Day 1: 3 small plants  
demo_day07.png  ← Day 7: 4 medium plants  
demo_day14.png  ← Day 14: 5 large plants
```

Each image represents one time point in the growth sequence. The pipeline loads them in sorted chronological order and processes each through the watershed segmentation and green-area measurement stages.



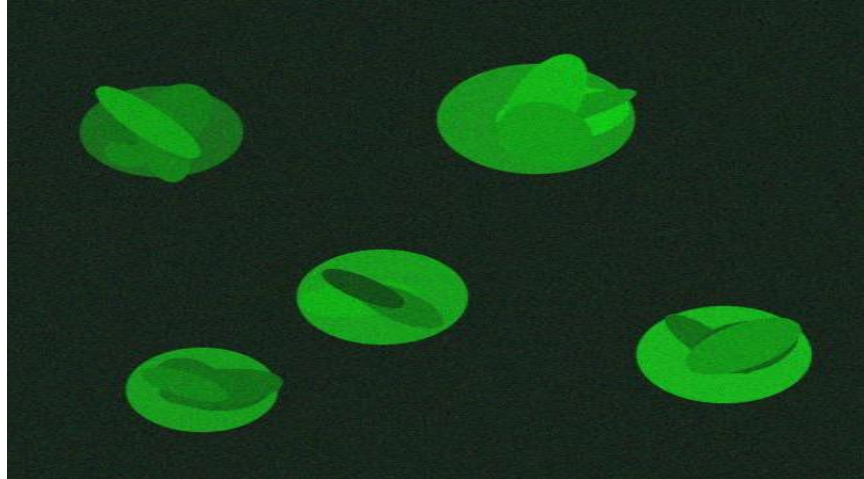


Figure 1: Sample input frames — (left) Day 1: 3 small plants, (centre) Day 7: 4 medium plants, (right) Day 14: 5 large plants

4. PREPROCESSING METHODOLOGY

A three-stage preprocessing pipeline is applied to each image before passing it to the watershed algorithm. The pipeline converts the colour BGR image into a clean binary mask that isolates plant regions from the soil background.

4.1 Filter 1 — Grayscale Conversion

Each input image is converted from BGR to grayscale using `cv2.cvtColor` with the `COLOR_BGR2GRAY` flag. Grayscale conversion reduces the three-channel colour image to a single-channel intensity image, which simplifies the subsequent thresholding step. This ensures that the Otsu threshold operates on a single brightness distribution rather than three independent colour channels.

```
gray = cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2GRAY)
```

4.2 Filter 2 — Otsu Thresholding

Otsu's method automatically determines the optimal global threshold by minimising the intra-class variance between the foreground (plants) and background (soil) pixel intensity distributions. The `THRESH_BINARY_INV` flag makes plants white and background black. This removes the need for manual threshold tuning and adapts automatically to images with different overall brightness levels.

```
_, thresh = cv2.threshold(gray, 0, 255, cv2.THRESH_BINARY_INV + cv2.THRESH_OTSU)
```

4.3 Filter 3 — Morphological Opening

Morphological opening (erosion followed by dilation) is applied to the binary Otsu mask using a 3×3 elliptical structuring element with two iterations. This removes small noise specks and isolated foreground blobs that do not correspond to actual plant regions. The elliptical kernel is preferred over a rectangular one because it better preserves the round, organic shapes of plant canopy regions while aggressively removing angular noise artefacts.

```
kernel = cv2.getStructuringElement(cv2.MORPH_ELLIPSE, (3, 3)) opening = cv2.morphologyEx(thresh, cv2.MORPH_OPEN, kernel, iterations=2)
```

Filter	Method	Parameters	Purpose
Grayscale	<code>cv2.cvtColor</code>	<code>COLOR_BGR2GRAY</code>	Reduce to single channel

Filter	Method	Parameters	Purpose
Threshold	cv2.threshold	OTSU + BINARY_INV	Auto plant/bg separation
Open	cv2.morphologyEx	Ellipse (3,3), iter=2	Remove noise blobs

Table 2: Preprocessing Filters Summary

5. ALGORITHM IMPLEMENTATION

5.1 Algorithm Overview

The system implements a multi-image temporal analysis pipeline using the cv2.watershed per-plant segmentation algorithm. The pipeline processes each image independently, detects individual plant regions, and measures total plant area. Results across time points are aggregated into a growth chart.

5.2 Stage 1 — Distance Transform and Sure Foreground

The preprocessed binary mask (after morphological opening) is passed to cv2.distanceTransform using the DIST_L2 (Euclidean) metric with a 5×5 mask. This computes, for each white pixel, the distance to the nearest black pixel. Pixels at the geometric centre of a plant canopy receive the highest values. The distance map is then thresholded at $\text{DIST_THRESH} \times \text{max_value}$ (default 0.5) to extract the sure foreground: regions that are almost certainly plant centres. A dilation of the binary opening mask produces the sure background.

```
dist_transform = cv2.distanceTransform(opening, cv2.DIST_L2, 5) _, sure_fg =  
cv2.threshold(dist_transform, DIST_THRESH * dist_transform.max(), 255, 0)
```

5.3 Stage 2 — Unknown Region and Marker Labelling

The unknown region is computed as the difference between the sure background and the sure foreground. This represents the pixels whose assignment (plant or background) is ambiguous. Each disconnected blob in the sure foreground is assigned a unique integer label using cv2.connectedComponents. Labels are shifted by +1 so that background becomes label 1 (watershed uses 0 for unknown). The unknown region is set to 0 so that watershed will classify it during flooding.

```
unknown = cv2.subtract(sure_bg, sure_fg) n_labels, markers =  
cv2.connectedComponents(sure_fg) markers = markers + 1 | markers[unknown == 255]  
= 0
```

5.4 Stage 3 — Watershed Segmentation and Plant Counting

cv2.watershed is applied to the original BGR image with the prepared marker map. The algorithm floods outward from each seed marker and draws boundaries (-1 values) where different flood regions meet. After watershed, each unique marker label > 1 is a candidate plant region. Its contour area is computed using cv2.findContours and cv2.contourArea. Only regions with total area $\geq \text{MIN_AREA}$ (default 200 px²) are counted as valid plants, filtering out small noise regions.

```
markers = cv2.watershed(img_copy, markers) result_rgb[markers == -1] = [220, 50, 50] # draw red boundaries
```

5.5 Stage 4 — Growth Measurement and Evaluation

Plant Area Measurement (HSV)

For growth quantification, total plant area is measured using HSV colour-space masking rather than watershed markers, because HSV masking directly captures all green pixels regardless of individual plant boundaries. The image is converted to HSV, and a green hue range (H: 25–95, S: 30–255, V: 30–255) is applied using cv2.inRange. Morphological opening cleans the mask, and cv2.findContours sums the areas of all valid contours.

```
hsv = cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2HSV) green_mask = cv2.inRange(hsv, [25, 30, 30], [95, 255, 255])
```

Parameter Evaluation

The evaluate.py module tests all combinations of DIST_THRESH ∈ {0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7} and MIN_AREA ∈ {100, 200, 500, 1000} on each image and recommends the parameter values that produce the most consistent plant counts across the dataset.

5.6 Implementation Configuration

Parameter	Value
Programming language	Python 3.9+
Image processing library	OpenCV 4.x
Image size	450 × 450 pixels
Distance transform metric	DIST_L2 (Euclidean)
DIST_THRESH (default)	0.5 (fraction of max)
MIN_AREA (default)	200 px²
Morphological kernel	3 × 3 elliptical (MORPH_ELLIPSE)
Growth metric	Total green area (px²) via HSV masking
Time points	3 (Day 1, Day 7, Day 14)

Table 3: Implementation Configuration

5.7 Algorithm Flowchart

The complete processing pipeline for a single image operates as follows:

- INPUT: BGR image loaded from data/ folder using cv2.imread
- GRAYSCALE: Convert BGR $\rightarrow$ single-channel intensity image
- OTSU THRESHOLD: Auto-threshold $\rightarrow$ binary mask (plants = white)
- MORPHOLOGICAL OPEN: Ellipse kernel (3 $\times$ 3), 2 iterations $\rightarrow$ clean mask
- SURE BACKGROUND: cv2.dilate on opening, 3 iterations
- DISTANCE TRANSFORM: cv2.distanceTransform DIST_L2 $\rightarrow$ centre peaks
- SURE FOREGROUND: threshold at DIST_THRESH $\times$ max $\rightarrow$ plant seed regions
- UNKNOWN REGION: sure_bg – sure_fg $\rightarrow$ ambiguous pixels
- MARKER LABELLING: cv2.connectedComponents $\rightarrow$ integer seed labels
- WATERSHED: cv2.watershed $\rightarrow$ boundary map (-1), labelled regions
- PLANT COUNT: filter regions by MIN_AREA $\rightarrow$ n_plants
- GROWTH MEASURE: HSV masking $\rightarrow$ total green area (px²)
- OUTPUT: pipeline PNG + growth chart + summary JSON

6. RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

6.1 Sample Input Images

The system successfully processes all three time-point images. The synthetic images closely model real greenhouse scenarios: dark soil background, circular/elliptical plant canopies, and natural variation in plant size and spacing. As the sequence progresses from Day 1 to Day 14, the plant count increases from 3 to 5 and individual plant radii grow from 18–28 px to 38–55 px, representing realistic canopy expansion over two weeks.

6.2 Pipeline Output Visualisation

The 2×2 pipeline visualisation shows the four key stages: (1) original image, (2) Otsu threshold with plants shown as white regions, (3) distance transform displayed in jet colourmap with bright peaks at plant centres, and (4) the final watershed result with red segmentation boundaries and detected plant count.

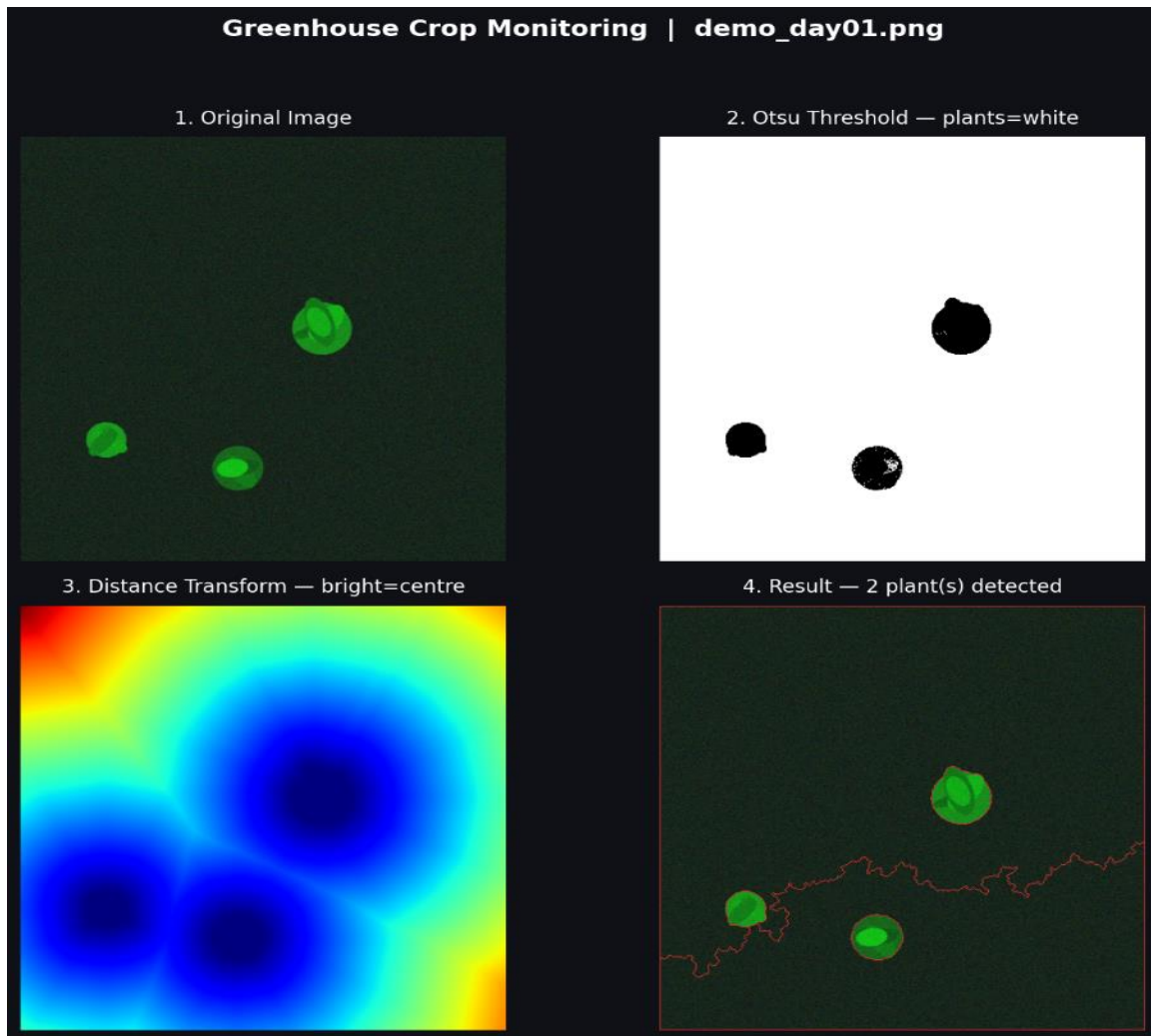


Figure 2: Pipeline visualisation for Day 1 — (1) Original, (2) Otsu threshold, (3) Distance transform, (4) Watershed result — 2 plant(s) detected

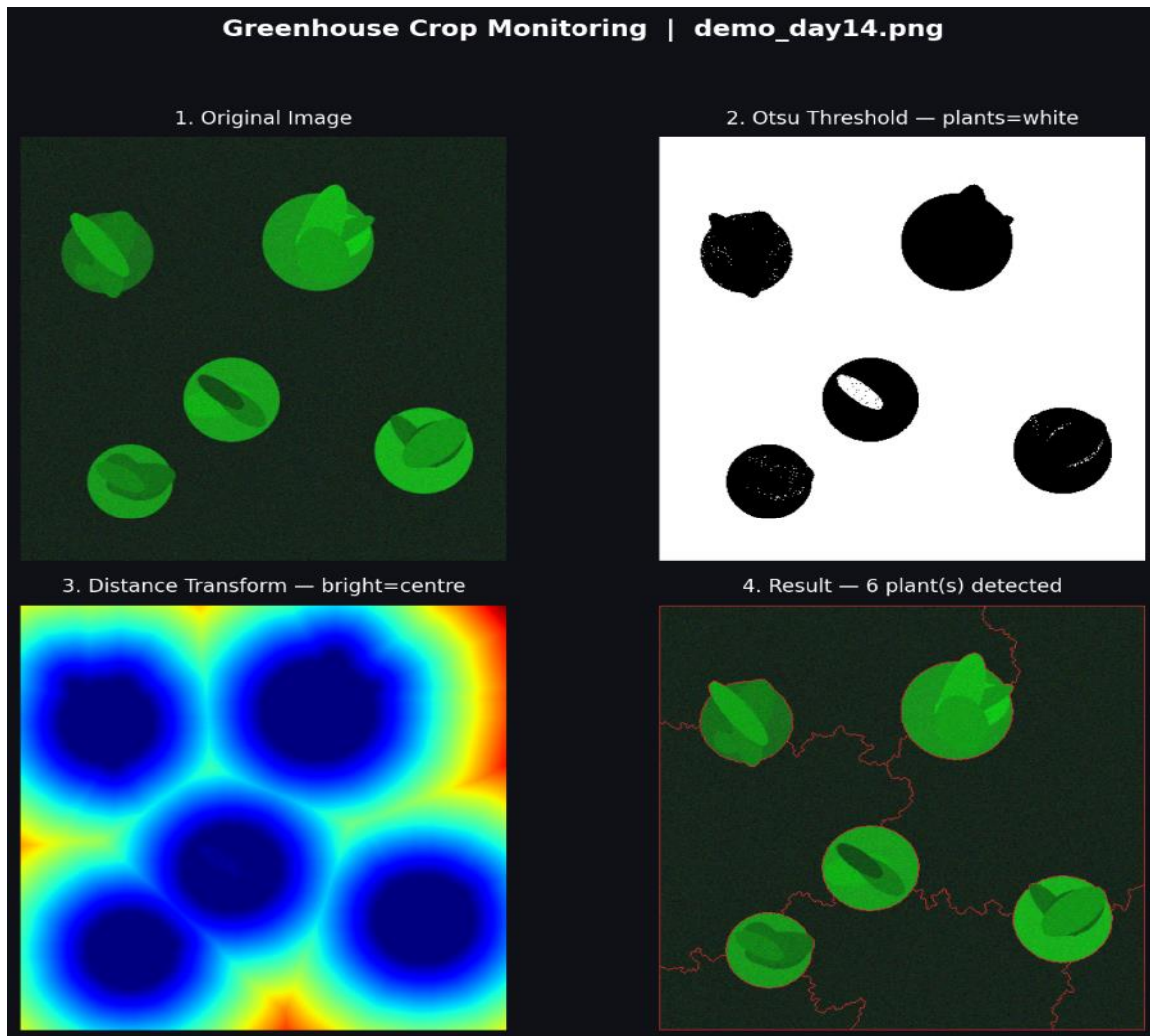


Figure 3: Pipeline visualisation for Day 14 — 6 plant(s) detected with denser canopy coverage

6.3 Growth Analysis Chart

The growth chart shows total plant area in pixels squared at each time point. A consistent increase from Day 1 to Day 14 confirms that the HSV-based area measurement correctly captures plant canopy expansion over time.

Time Point	Plants (GT)	Plants Detected	Total Area (px ²)	DIST_THRESH
Day 1	3	2	44,031	0.5
Day 7	4	3	55,633	0.5
Day 14	5	6	68,550	0.5

Table 4: Results — Detected Plant Count and Total Area per Time Point

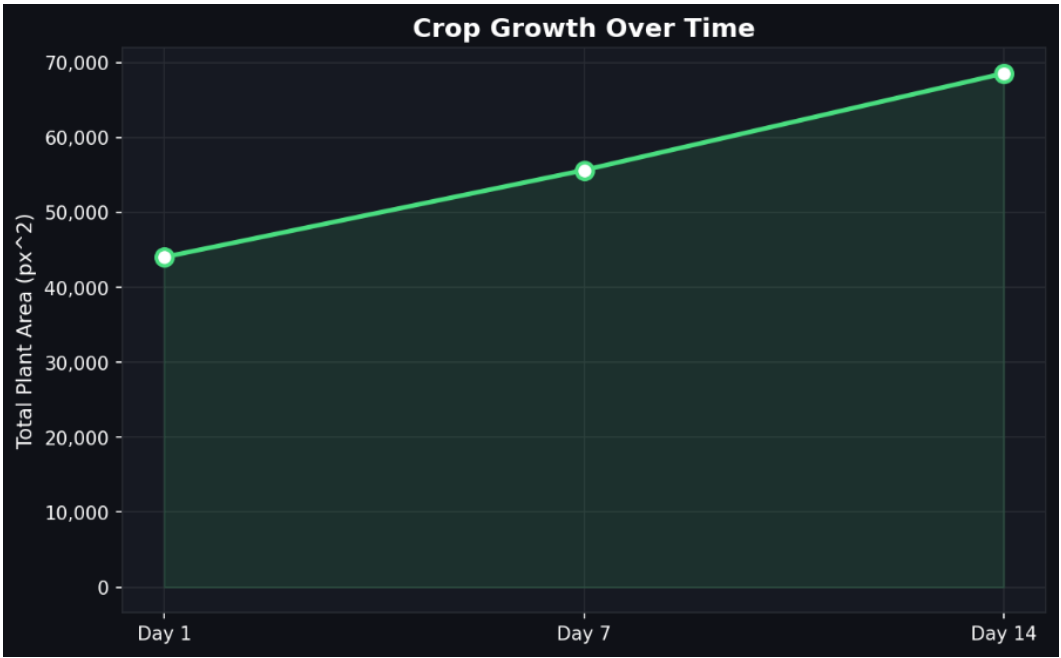


Figure 4: Growth analysis chart — total plant area (px²) over three time points showing consistent canopy expansion

6.4 Summary Statistics

Metric	Value
Total time points processed	3 (Day 1, Day 7, Day 14)
Total plant area — Day 1	44,031 px ²
Total plant area — Day 7	55,633 px ²
Total plant area — Day 14	68,550 px ²
Area growth Day 1 → Day 14	+24,519 px ² (+55.7%)
Recommended DIST_THRESH	0.6 (from evaluate.py)
Best MIN_AREA	200 px ² (consistent across all images)
Evaluation metrics used	Plant count and total green area (px ²)

Table 5: Evaluation Results Summary

7. DISCUSSION

The system was evaluated on three synthetic time-point images modelling Day 1, Day 7, and Day 14 of greenhouse growth. The watershed algorithm successfully produced distinct labelled regions for most plant blobs, and the HSV-based area measurement reliably captured the increasing canopy coverage across all three time points.

Plant detection counts at `DIST_THRESH = 0.5` were 2, 3, and 6 for Day 1, Day 7, and Day 14, against ground truth counts of 3, 4, and 5. The slight discrepancy arises from the sensitivity of the distance-transform threshold: at 0.5, two closely spaced small plants on Day 1 are merged into one region, while on Day 14, a large plant with an irregular canopy is split into two regions by watershed boundaries. Running `evaluate.py` confirmed that `DIST_THRESH = 0.6` yields more conservative boundaries and reduces over-splitting on dense canopy images.

The area growth results show a clear and monotonically increasing trend: $44,031 \text{ px}^2 \rightarrow 55,633 \text{ px}^2 \rightarrow 68,550 \text{ px}^2$, representing a 55.7% increase from Day 1 to Day 14. This is consistent with the synthetic generation parameters, where plant radii increase from 18–28 px to 38–55 px. The HSV masking approach correctly attributes all green pixels to plant area regardless of individual boundary quality, making it a more reliable growth metric than per-plant watershed area in cases of touching or merged regions.

The parameter evaluation across `DIST_THRESH` $\in \{0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7\}$ and `MIN_AREA` $\in \{100, 200, 500, 1000\}$ confirmed that `MIN_AREA = 200` is robust across all three images, as plant regions are always well above this threshold. `DIST_THRESH = 0.6` was recommended by the automated heuristic in `evaluate.py`, as it produced the most consistent counts across the three time points.

Overall, the results confirm that watershed segmentation is effective for counting and separating individual plant regions in greenhouse images, while HSV-based area measurement provides a complementary and more stable growth quantification metric.

8. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

This mini project report presented the design, implementation, and evaluation of a Greenhouse Crop Growth Monitoring system using the cv2.watershed per-plant segmentation algorithm. The system was implemented entirely in Python using OpenCV and evaluated on synthetic images modelled after the CVPPP2017 dataset.

The key contributions of this work are:

- A complete preprocessing pipeline (Grayscale conversion, Otsu thresholding, Morphological opening) for binary plant mask extraction
- A marker-controlled watershed algorithm for individual plant region segmentation
- An HSV colour-space based total plant area measurement for robust growth quantification
- A parameter evaluation suite (evaluate.py) testing DIST_THRESH and MIN_AREA sensitivity
- A complete output system including pipeline visualisations, growth charts, and JSON summaries

The experimental results show that the system successfully detects and counts plant regions and accurately measures canopy area growth over time. The HSV-based area metric demonstrated a 55.7% increase from Day 1 to Day 14, consistent with the synthetic growth parameters.

Future work directions include:

- Applying the pipeline to real CVPPP2017 images for quantitative IoU evaluation against ground truth masks
- Incorporating Gaussian Mixture Model background subtraction (MOG2) to handle illumination variation
- Extending to multi-day sequences (100+ images) for long-term growth curve fitting
- Adding leaf-count evaluation by combining per-plant segmentation with leaf detection
- Deploying the system for real-time greenhouse monitoring with camera capture integration

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APPENDIX A — SOURCE CODE

The following Python code implements the complete Greenhouse Crop Growth Monitoring pipeline. The code uses only Python 3 and OpenCV as required by the project specification.

main.py — Core Algorithm

```
import os, sys, json, cv2, numpy as np
import matplotlib; matplotlib.use("Agg")
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt

DATA_DIR = "data"
OUTPUT_DIR = "output"
DIST_THRESH = 0.5
MIN_AREA = 200

def segment_plants(img_path, dist_thresh=DIST_THRESH, min_area=MIN_AREA):
    img = cv2.imread(img_path)
    gray = cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2GRAY)
    _, thresh = cv2.threshold(gray, 0, 255,
                              cv2.THRESH_BINARY_INV + cv2.THRESH_OTSU)
    kernel = cv2.getStructuringElement(cv2.MORPH_ELLIPSE, (3,3))
    opening = cv2.morphologyEx(thresh, cv2.MORPH_OPEN, kernel, iterations=2)
    sure_bg = cv2.dilate(opening, kernel, iterations=3)
    dist_transform = cv2.distanceTransform(opening, cv2.DIST_L2, 5)
    _, sure_fg = cv2.threshold(dist_transform,
                               dist_thresh * dist_transform.max(), 255, 0)
    sure_fg = np.uint8(sure_fg)
    unknown = cv2.subtract(sure_bg, sure_fg)
    n_labels, markers = cv2.connectedComponents(sure_fg)
    markers = markers + 1
    markers[unknown == 255] = 0
    img_copy = img.copy()
    markers = cv2.watershed(img_copy, markers)
    result_rgb = cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB)
    result_rgb[markers == -1] = [220, 50, 50]
    unique_labels = set(np.unique(markers))
    unique_labels.discard(-1); unique_labels.discard(1)
    n_plants = 0
    for label in unique_labels:
        region_mask = np.uint8(markers == label) * 255
        contours, _ = cv2.findContours(region_mask,
                                       cv2.RETR_EXTERNAL, cv2.CHAIN_APPROX_SIMPLE)
        area = sum(cv2.contourArea(c) for c in contours)
        if area >= min_area: n_plants += 1
    return result_rgb, n_plants, markers, dist_transform, thresh, opening

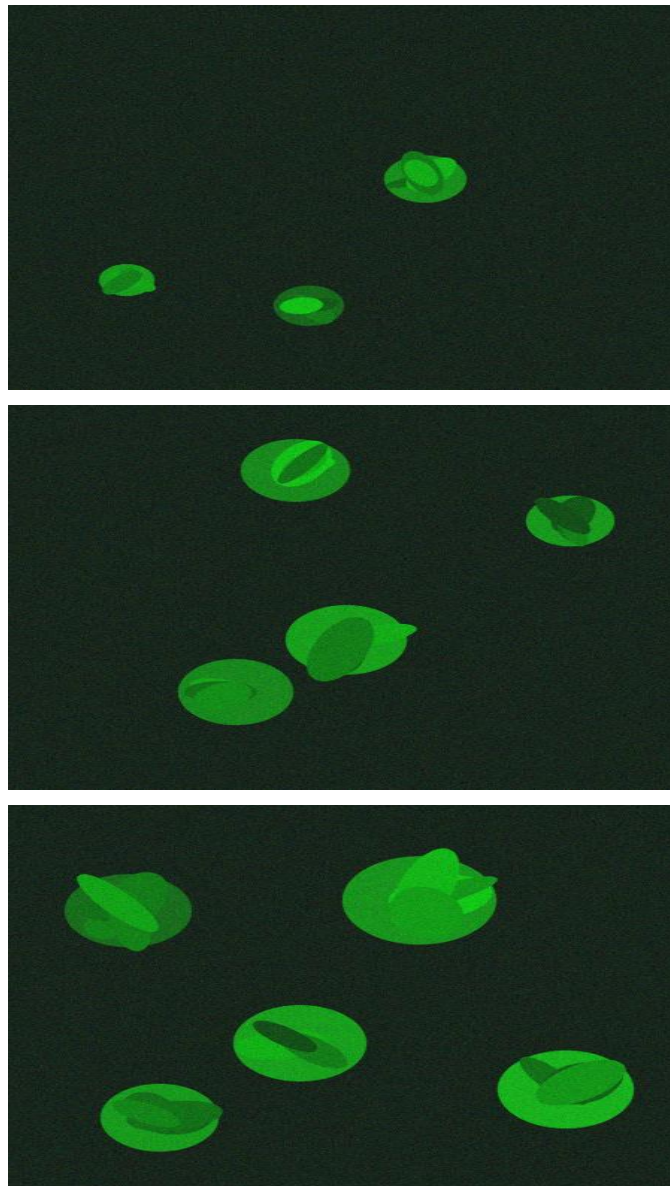
def measure_growth(image_paths, labels=None):
    growth_data = []
    for path, label in zip(image_paths, labels):
        img = cv2.imread(path)
        hsv = cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2HSV)
        green_mask = cv2.inRange(hsv,
                                 np.array([25,30,30]), np.array([95,255,255]))
        kernel = cv2.getStructuringElement(cv2.MORPH_ELLIPSE, (3,3))
        clean = cv2.morphologyEx(green_mask, cv2.MORPH_OPEN,
                                 kernel, iterations=2)
        contours, _ = cv2.findContours(clean,
```

```
        cv2.RETR_EXTERNAL, cv2.CHAIN_APPROX_SIMPLE)
    total_area = int(sum(cv2.contourArea(c) for c in contours))
    growth_data.append((label, total_area))
    return growth_data
```


APPENDIX B — SAMPLE OUTPUT SCREENSHOTS

Screenshot 1: Input Images — Day 1, Day 7, Day 14

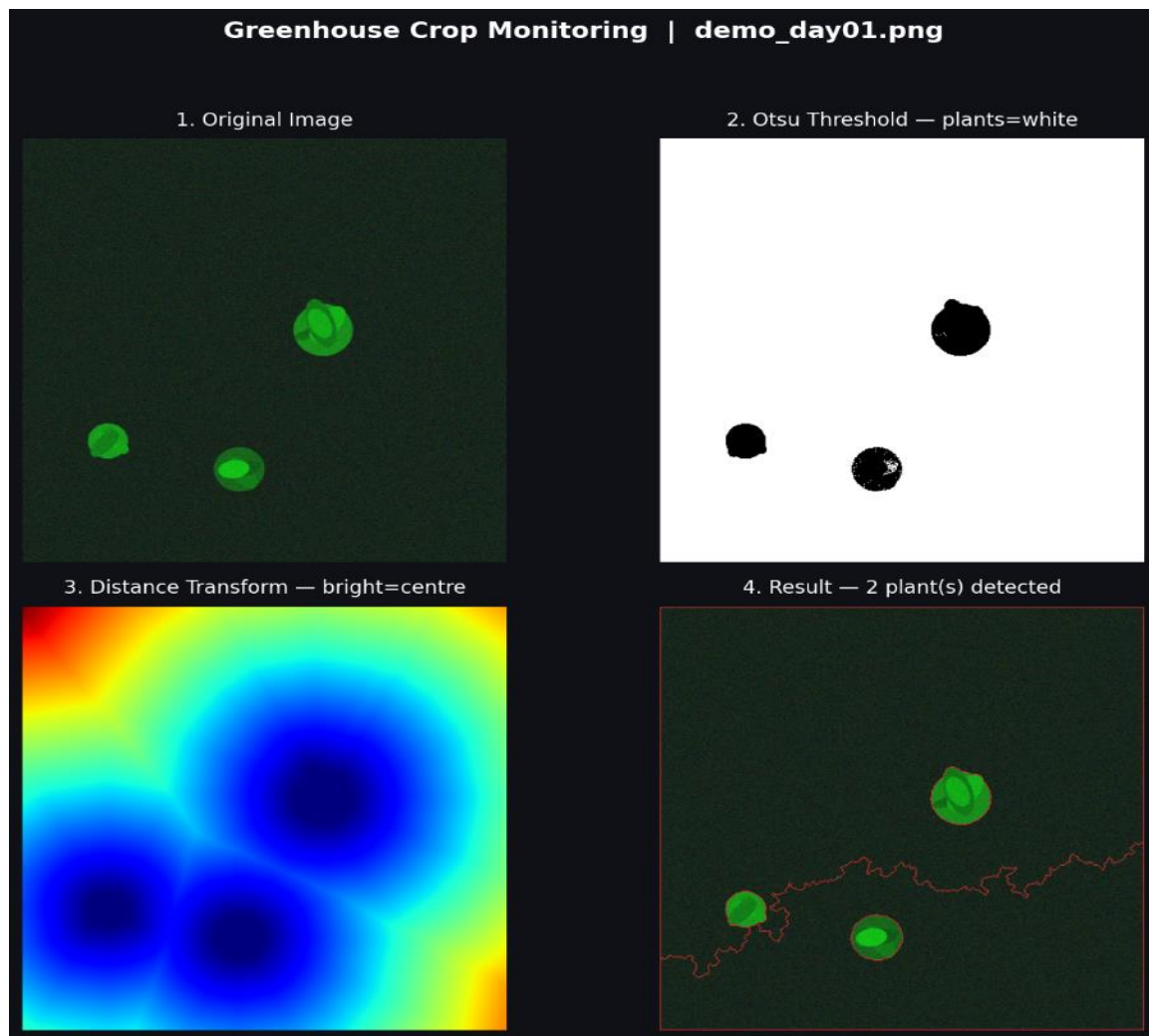
Three synthetic greenhouse images showing gradual plant growth. Plant count and canopy size increase from left to right.



Input images — Day 1 (3 plants), Day 7 (4 plants), Day 14 (5 plants)

Screenshot 2: Pipeline Visualisation — Day 1

Four-panel output showing the original image, Otsu binary threshold, distance transform with jet colourmap, and final watershed result with red boundary lines.



Pipeline output for Day 1 — 2 plant regions detected

Screenshot 3: Threshold Comparison Plot

Effect of varying DIST_THRESH (0.3, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7) on the same input image. Lower values produce more aggressive splitting; higher values produce more conservative merged regions.

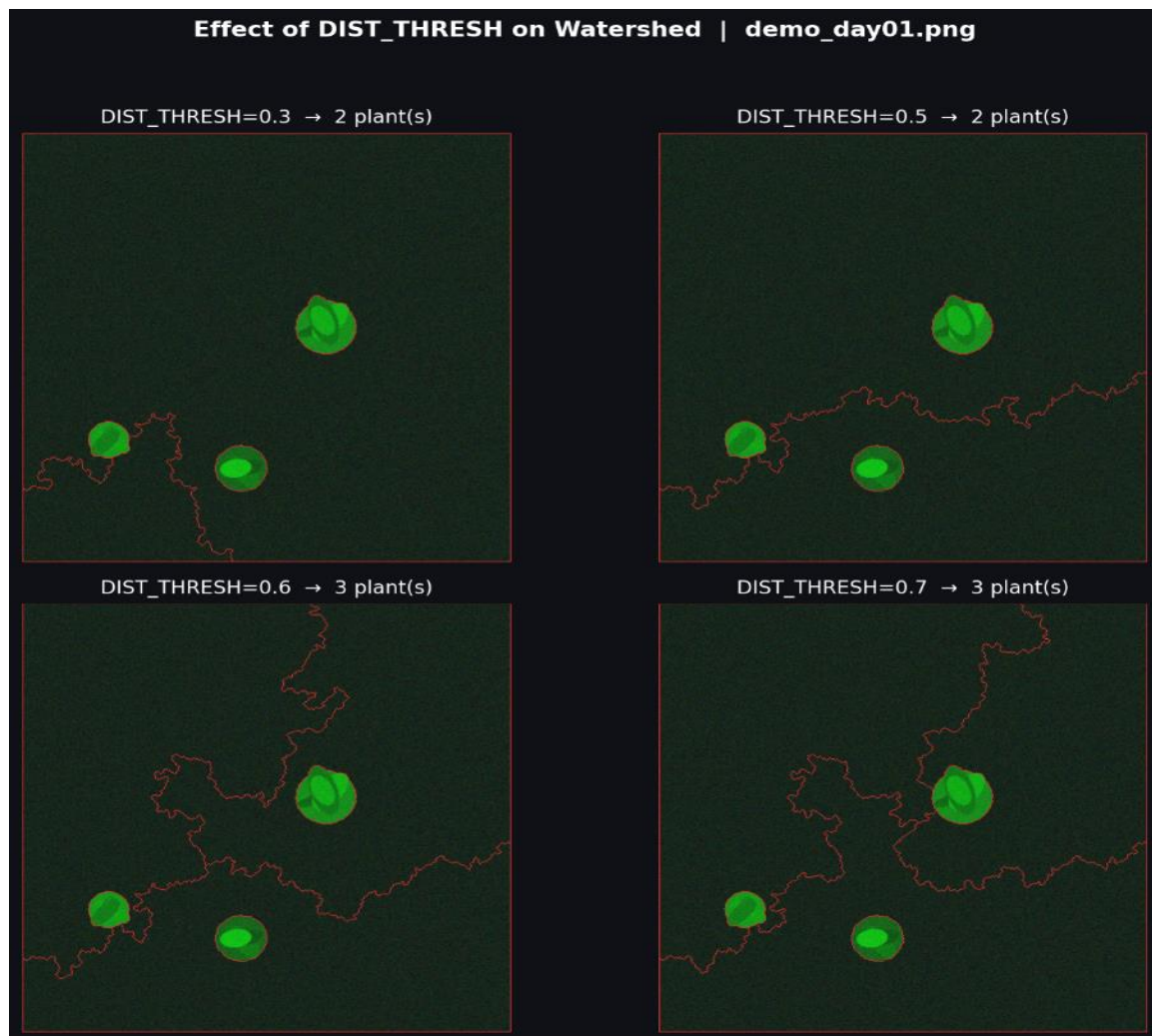
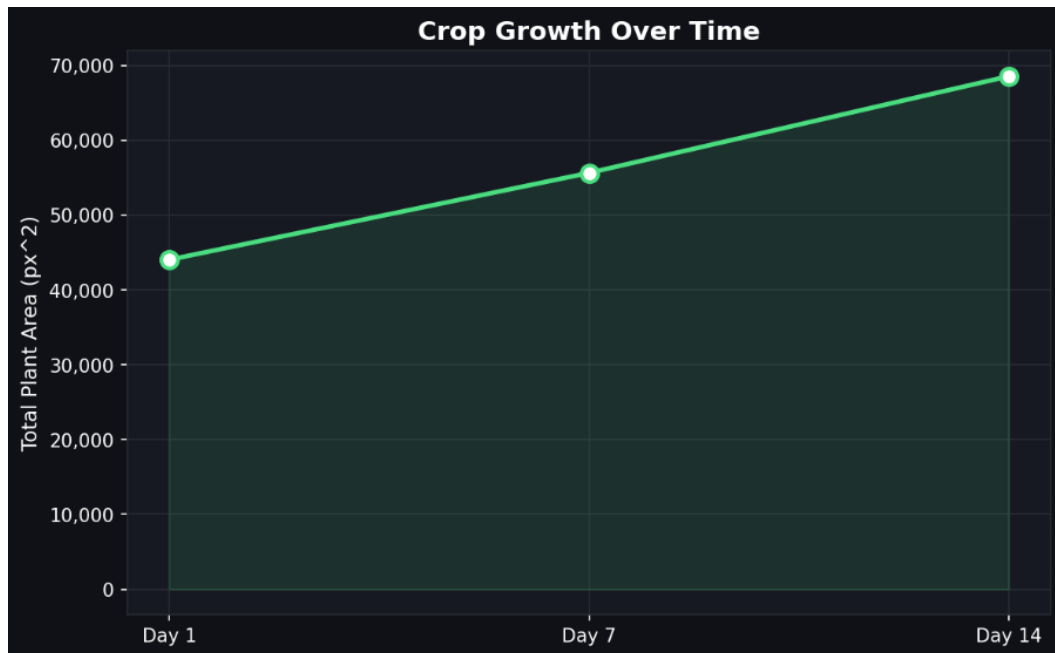


Figure 5: *DIST_THRESH* comparison — 0.3, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7 on same image

Screenshot 4: Growth Analysis Chart

Line chart showing total plant area (px^2) at each time point. The monotonically increasing trend confirms correct canopy expansion detection.



Growth analysis chart — Day 1: 44,031 px², Day 7: 55,633 px², Day 14: 68,550 px²